

Using the "Prayer Book and Psalms" pocket edition

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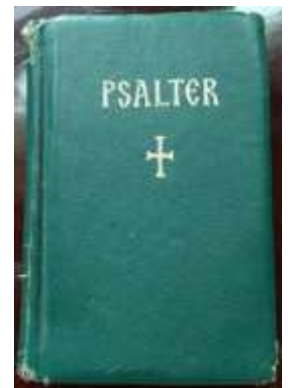
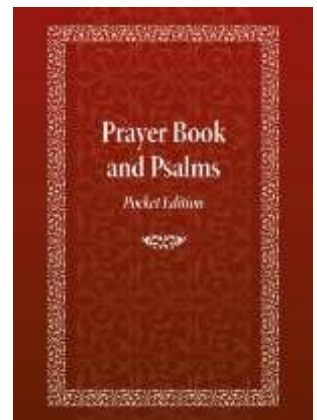
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I recommend that any catechumen, inquirer, a person new to Orthodoxy, and especially new to having a rule of prayer use a prayer book. This is not the only thing you will use for prayer, but it is an excellent guide.

The general comments apply to any prayer book that you use. We have two English prayerbooks at the church. The "Prayer Book and Psalms" has all the prayers that are in the so-called "Jordanville Prayer Book" plus all of the Psalms of David at the back. It's very economical and small. The Jordanville prayer book is an old standard. Its print is bigger, but it does not have the whole Psalter in it. It has a few additional things that the pocket prayer book does not have, but to tell the truth, I've never really used them, and they are not very useful to me. All of the things that are useful in the Jordanville prayer book are in the pocket prayer book. I use them interchangeably for prayers.

I don't use the Psalter in the pocket prayer book because I prefer the Boston Psalter. We use that Psalter in our church services, and I have many of the Psalms memorized. It's not superior to the Psalter in the pocket prayer book, just more familiar to me. If you want to become accustomed to the Psalms as we say them in church, I recommend that you spend another \$15 and buy the Boston Psalter. We call it the "Boston Psalter" because a monastery in Boston published it. I have been using it for over 30 years.



Why use a prayer book?

Orthodox prayer is different. Anyone who delves deeply into the Orthodox prayer and was previously a Christian of another confession soon learns that Orthodox prayer is very different. It is more deeply theological, and it is more compunctionate. It is longer. There are many doxologies in it. The doxology is a short prayer that glorifies God, and in Orthodox usage, they are usually deeply theological and about the Holy Trinity. Examples of doxologies would be: "Glory to the Father and to the Son and to the Holy Spirit" and "Glory to Thee our God, glory to Thee." We also say: "Lord have mercy," many times, sometimes just once, but usually three times or 12 times or even 40 times. This repetition is something

that a person may not be accustomed to. I was not, but it is definitely grown on me. When we say things frequently and repeat them, there is a certain intensity that the soul feels. *Those who have done this know what I am saying.*

Orthodox prayer also frequently mentions the saints and the Mother of God. Compared to so-called, for lack of a better term, "Protestant prayer," Orthodox prayer is very different. It may be very strange to people at first. It was strange to me, even though I came from a former Roman Catholic background. I was so upset by the obsessive emphasis about Mary and the deemphasis of Christ in favor of the Pope in Catholic education classes that it bothered me to see the Orthodox say things like, "Most Holy Theotokos save us."

There is much to say about this phrase, which makes many Protestants believe that Orthodox are guilty of idolatry. We would actually say that they are guilty of not honoring the Mother of God, whom Jesus Christ clearly honored. We would also say that they are guilty of not abiding by her prophecy in the Gospel of Luke when she said, "all generations shall call me blessed." We would also say that they are guilty of not understanding on a profound level the incarnation and the absolute necessity of a mere human being saying "yes" to God. We will talk more about this in another letter. If this bothers you, I hope you can do what I did when I was a college junior and senior. I asked God to enlighten me, and I said the prayers, sometimes even gritting my teeth. Because I asked the Holy Spirit to enlighten me, I was enlightened. It took years for me to deeply feel the intimate relationship the church has with God's mother. If you don't feel this intimate relationship, but you believe that the church is true and therefore you should have an intimate relationship, then proceed with faith and say the prayers. God will enlighten you also.

The holy apostle asked the Lord to teach them to pray. He responded by telling them to pray "in this way," and then he recited the "Our Father" for them. This prayer is not only recited verbatim by us many times a day, but all of our prayers are modeled on it. The prayer book helps us to pray according to this model. It is not an easy thing to do on our own. Christianity is entirely a revealed religion. We learn about God because God reveals Himself to us. He reveals Himself to us in any way He wishes, and this includes the prayers of the church, the services, and the church's customs. All of these things help us to acquire the mind of Christ.

In my experience, when in Protestant prayer settings, usually someone was asked to pray extemporaneously. This prayer was always formulaic even though it was extemporaneous and mostly consisted of praising God and asking Him for things. I called it the "*I just*" prayer because the first line usually said something like "Father, (or Father God), *I just* want to thank you" or words to that effect. It then sprawled on and on, especially with an unskilled person, and any attempts at theological expressions were shallow and sometimes just wrong. Theological expressions are critical in Orthodox prayer, and theology is hard to get right. We must live it and study it to understand. Saying an "I just" prayer with beautiful and profound and comprehensive theological expressions is beyond most people's capacity. It is better to say such theological prayers from written down prayers, which have been said literally trillions of times and have entered into the mind of the church.

Another reason to use the prayer book is that it is very difficult to pray extemporaneously and creatively for an extended period of time. Our prayer must be from the heart, but we will not learn to pray from the heart by saying very short prayers or infrequent prayers. We believe in *quality and quantity*. Saying prayers from the prayer book, for instance, saying the morning prayers, ensures that we will say deeply theological and compunctionate prayers and will say them over the course of a considerable amount of time. Saying those prayers might take 20 minutes. That is a significant amount of time for most people, especially beginners.

Using the prayers from a prayer book also is a profoundly humble thing to do. Orthodox Christians deeply feel themselves to be an organic part of the body of Christ, which has a history. We fear innovation and avoid it as best as we can. If we consider our made-up prayer to be inferior to the prayers of our fathers, we will be very safe.

There is always an opportunity to speak to God in our own words. We should do this every day, but we should not depend on it for our prayer rule. We should have a prayer rule. There is nothing legalistic about this. This is one of the complaints that people outside of Orthodoxy have about our prayer. They think that it is confining and that it is legalistic. The opposite is true. When we pray the prayers written with compunction as best we can and with attention as best we can, the soul is very free to feel the grace of God deeply. *Try this, and if you stick with it, you will know that what I am saying is true.*

There is another excellent reason to use the prayer book. A careful catechist will instruct the catechumen in prayer. They might say, for instance: "Say the morning prayers, as many as you can, in the morning before you do anything else." When we do this, we are obedient to another human being. It is very rare in Protestant confessions: to do our prayer in obedience to someone else. It's always based on our inclinations and our own perceived needs.

It is excellent always to find an opportunity to be obedient. Everyone can find this opportunity. We fast in a certain way, and I recommend that everyone try to fast according to the rule. You should try to be obedient, whether you understand fasting or not. I remember someone told me that they love seafood above everything, especially shrimp. Shrimp is always allowed on any day. They thought that that was foolish, so they didn't eat shrimp but ate meat during a fast. They were disobedient. Don't fall into this trap. It is good to do what we are told. It is good to *choose* to do what you are told. You are making a *free choice* to be obedient. *You will reap extraordinary dividends in choosing to obey the church in the way we fast and in the way we pray.*

As you grow in your prayer life, you will find that the freedom of Orthodox prayer is unparalleled. When I became Orthodox, and even before I became Orthodox, I said the morning and evening prayers. I used those prayers for many years. I don't use them as often anymore because I mostly read the Psalter and certain other prayers, and my commemoration list and prostrations are longer. It took years for me to get to this point. Now I am free to use the morning and evening prayers, say the Psalter, or read other prayers such as canons or Akathists. You will also have this freedom, but you must "put in your time." Nobody will force you to use the prayer book, although your catechist or spiritual father may give you a prayer rule. You have free will. You can choose to obey or not obey. Experience in the church's life shows that choosing to obey will make the soul grow in ways you cannot imagine.

I think this is enough of an apology for using the prayer book. Perhaps you have other reasons why using the prayer book is useful to you. Please let me know about them, and I may incorporate them in this letter in a second edition.

How should we use the prayer book?

I recommend to you that you begin by saying the morning and evening prayers. Say them as completely as you can and with as much attention as you can. Try to say them before you do anything else in the morning. Try to say them where it is quiet, and preferably where you are standing before your icons. You may listen to them if you wish, but I think it is MUCH better in the beginning to say them yourself. It is better, in the beginning, to say them aloud and to learn to chant them or to read them properly. I did this for many years even though sound during prayer, even my own sound, generally is not pleasant to me. Now I say them "in my head," and I literally chant them in my head.

You will learn how to chant by listening to it and attempting to mimic what you hear. Chanting is melodic reading. We are singing, but we are not singing a melody, like singing a song. We are chanting on one or two notes and allowing the text to determine if our voice goes up or down slightly. This is a learned skill. Chanting must emphasize the words and the rhythm of the text, but not the meaning. We should never emphasize the meaning of the words we are chanting or reading, especially if we chant at church or others are listening. Perhaps when you are reading with compunction alone with emotion, you will naturally stress certain words. This is perfectly fine, but don't attempt to emphasize words. You may also just read the words aloud. Try to read the words rhythmically, according to the way they are written. This is all a learned skill. We will go over this skill.

The morning prayers in the pocket prayer book begin on page 5. You can read them verbatim. Recognize that the *italics* are instructions, which you probably don't need to read more than once.

When the Trinity is mentioned or alluded to, you should make the sign of the cross. We have talked about the sign of the cross, and you must make it properly. Why should you make it properly? Because it is the precious cross, and we should honor it, and because we should be obedient to the way things are done in the church. You should make a free-will decision to choose to do the cross carefully and according to the established order. You will reap benefits if you do this.

We should make the sign of the cross when we say "Glory to thee, our God, glory to thee.", Or the so-called "Trisagion," "Holy God, Holy Mighty, Holy Immortal, have mercy on us." Of course, we should make the sign of the cross when we say, "Glory to the Father and to the Son and to the Holy Spirit, both now and ever and unto the ages of ages, amen." Many people make the sign of the cross for the prayer "O most Holy Trinity, have mercy on us,". You can make the sign of the cross practically anytime you wish, but you should also know that whenever the Trinity is invoked, it is traditional to make the sign.

Another letter will discuss the sign of the cross in more detail, but a short description is this. Take your thumb and your first two fingers and pinch them together. Your little finger and ring finger should be pressed down into your palm. Touch first your forehead with your three fingers, then your belly, and then your right shoulder, then cross over and touch your left shoulder. It is very important that if you make the sign of the cross that is upright. That is, don't make the sign of the cross that looks like it's upside down.

If the morning prayers are too long for you, try to say them through the Creed on pages 9 and 10. That would be a very good beginning for you. If you can say the rest of the prayers, which began on page 10 and go through to page 17, that is wonderful. If you cannot keep attention, then at least read from pages 5 through 10. It is essential to say the Creed every day because you should have it memorized. You should also say the 50th Psalm because it is the quintessential example of how we should repent. We will talk about the 50th Psalm in another letter. It brings us through all phases of repentance, including forgiveness and healing.

In the evening, read the prayers before sleep, which begin on page 28. We start the same way as the morning prayers. Try to say at least through the evening troparia on page 29, and then some number of the prayers beginning at page 30. The first of these prayers is the Prayer of St Macarius the Great. If you are unable to say many of these prayers, without fail, say prayer seven of St. John Chrysostom, which is a prayer for each hour of the day and night. This prayer consists of 24 prayers, in one short sentence each. I recommend that you say each one of them by making the sign of the cross and doing a prostration. If you're able to go all the way through to page 43 of the evening prayers, that is wonderful. If you cannot, but certain prayers move you, mark them with a light pencil mark and say those prayers without fail. Please always say the prayer of St. John Chrysostom.

At the very end of the evening prayers, on page 42, there is a daily confession of sins. This is not a so-called "laundry list." When you read these sins, you should be able to see that you have done all of these things, or could do all of these things, or have done these things in the past. Reading such a list humbles us.

What about the rest of the prayer book?

I recommend that you read the entire prayer book to become acquainted with it. There are beautiful "prayers during the day" that are after the morning prayers. Perhaps you like one of them. There are beautiful and theological Troparia and Kontakia and Canons and Akathists. We will talk about all of these kinds of prayer. It would be much better if when we talk about these prayers, you've already read them and perhaps are even using them because they move you in some way. At least, read over all the prayers at least three times. You will not know what is in the prayer book if do you have read the entire thing.

What should we pray beside the prayers of the prayer book?

Without fail, every day, we should commemorate those we love, and anyone who touches our soul somehow, and especially anybody that we have some problem with, whether it is current or way in the past. Make a list, write it down. I made lists from the very beginning of my Orthodox life. I would use notebooks and recopy them when they got too messy. Now I have everything on my computer, and I print it out in booklets. It doesn't matter how you do it, but you must do it. We cannot say that we love unless we pray for those we say we love.

It does not need to be complicated right now. It never needs to be complicated. I pray for every single one of the catechumens or inquirers and every single person in the parish and many people that were in the parish that I will likely never see again, and many people who have touched me or crossed my path in some way, every day. I also have a list of people that I pray for at the Divine liturgy. I can pray for all of those every day because there's not enough time, but the list of people I pray for is extensive. I followed a rule that I want you to follow. Add people to your list carefully. Don't add 500 people at once. But if you add a person and they remain an important person to you in some way, never take them off the list. Of course, this does not apply to our prayers for sick people and things like that. But if you want to pray for your mother, you should never stop praying for your mother. If you want to pray for someone who wronged you in the past and you have bad thoughts about them, you should never stop praying for them. Add people to your list carefully. Certainly, your family, your friends, your pastor, and anybody else that in some way is affected your life in such a way that your heart is touched by them should be on the list.

How should you pray for people? I pray for people mostly by just saying, "Lord Jesus Christ have mercy upon 'name.'" For some of those people, I say the prayer with a prostration. I recommend that you do this also. If you cannot do a prostration, then do a bow. If you cannot do a bow, don't let that stop you. At least say the prayer.

Sometimes we want to pray more for a person. I don't recommend that you pray in a very specific way except for health or safety etc. For instance, you shouldn't say, "O God, help uncle Billy to stop drinking." It is better just to ask the Lord to have mercy upon uncle Billy. And if uncle Billy is drinking too much, it is even better to do a prostration when you say this prayer or to do three prayers with three prostrations. When I want to pray more for a person, I do more prostrations or more prayers.

There is another prayer that I used very much in the past and still do when I want to pray a little bit extra for a person. It is a prayer from an Old Believer prayer book. I recommend that you copy it out and use it for whoever you want.

To pray for someone more diligently:

From the Old Believer Prayer Book, with line 4 added

Save, O Lord, and have mercy *on Thy servant(s) _____, [bow]*
Deliver him *(her, them)* from every tribulation, wrath, and need *[bow]*,
From every sickness of soul and body, *[bow]*
Forgive him *(her, them)* every transgression, voluntary and involuntary, *[bow]*
Teach them to pray and to live with purpose. *[bow]*
And do whatever is profitable for our souls. *[bow]*.

After you finish your evening or your morning prayers, or at another point in them if you wish, during the weekdays of Great Lent, without fail, say the prayer of St. Ephrem. It is on page 64 of the pocket prayer book.

I recommend to everyone that they read the Psalms of David. Read them all. It is straightforward to read them sequentially. They are arranged in 20 “Kathismas” or chapters, and in each of these, there are three “Stasis” with a small number of psalms. Think of the stasis as a subchapter. You could read one stasis daily, or perhaps an entire Kathisma each day. It is very profitable to read through the Psalter in a week or perhaps in two weeks and then start over. The Psalter is the church’s prayer book. It contains every human condition and emotion and the proper response to it. It is not easy to understand, but it is immensely beautiful, and everyone should be reading the Psalter. Don’t get frustrated because some of the terminology is hard to understand. You will learn and until you have read it and you have lived it. If certain psalms move you, you have free will! You may choose to read those every day.

If you have any questions about using the prayer book or comments about it, please write me. If you're reading this on the catechumen list and want everybody else to see your question, please respond on the list.

May God bless you and help you in all things.

Priest Seraphim Holland